

Microsoft, and Quantcast Corp, all in the business of targeting ads at people online.

Some of the tracking files identified by the Journal were so detailed that they verged on being anonymous in name only. They enabled data-gathering companies to build personal profiles that included age, gender, race, zip code, income, marital status, and health concerns, along with recent purchases and favorite television shows and movies. In some cases a retailer could know that Mary Kenyon printed off a “20% off” coupon after searching for clothing discounts at Ebates.com on Monday morning and redeemed it later that afternoon at the store.

When someone joins a fan club on Facebook, their Facebook ID becomes visible to the merchandiser. When the consumer redeems the offer in the store, the coupon can be tracked back to the Facebook user. A company called RevTrax handles tracking for a large and varied group of companies. Jonathan Treiber, RevTrax’s co-founder was quoted in an April 20, 2010 *New York Times* article as saying, “Over time, we’ll be able to do much better profiling around certain IP addresses, to say, hey, this IP address is showing a proclivity for printed clothing apparel coupons and is really only responding to coupons greater than 20% off.”